around to the view that as long as no one was obliged to follow her, calling for peace was hardly objectionable. A Hindu could be overtly Hindu, I felt, if in the process she was being all-embracing in her expression of her faith, while not imposing it on others.

Hinduism is a life-affirming religion of joy and play (*leela*). It sees the world as suffused with radiance rather than darkness; as the Bhagavad Gita says, 'That splendour which is from the sun, which illumines this whole world, which is in the moon and in fire—know that splendour is also mine.' In turn this refulgence is Man's, since he is enjoined by the *Upanishad*s to see all beings in himself and himself in all things; he therefore radiates in his person the splendour of the Universe. Yes, the Hindu scriptures acknowledge the existence of human sorrow and suffering, but see them as part of an awakening to the transcendent. The Vedas do not ask why we suffer; they take human sorrow as a given, an affliction to be dealt with and overcome. The *Upanishad*s are more questioning of suffering; they use a word, *dukha*, sadness and existential distress, a word not found in the Vedas. Ideally one must be detached from such suffering, as the Gita teaches, and by eliminating sorrow in oneself through self-realisation, help remove it from others. This seems impossible for most ordinary people, and so the easier solution is to take refuge in the Lord.

Similarly, the Hindu scriptures speculate about the mystery of what lies beyond human life, but they are not obsessed with death; as Panikkar brilliantly put it, 'they seem to describe an existential attitude that takes cognisance of the phenomenon of death but denies to it any character of ultimacy… It is by integrating the fact of death into life, by reabsorbing, as it were, death into life…by finding a ground that is common to both death and life, that we can find the proper Vedic perspective.' This notion of the continuity between life and death is a particularly Hindu idea, with death, as it were, inbuilt into life. Panikkar again: 'The beyond is the unfathomable ocean which makes the beaches on this side worth walking and playing on.'

Hindus believe that, at most, religion can create a platform upon which the beautiful things in life can be attained. Destiny, knowledge, reflection and prayer may equip you to achieve fulfilment. The Hindu is